

APUSH: Decades Project Individual Research

Name: Bruce Peters	Period: 5
Decade: 1980s	

***Note on the use AI.** Please do your own writing. We are asking about your ideas and thoughts on a subject that you **CHOSE** to research. This is your chance to show authentic and meaningful work. Please have integrity and do your best.

Use [THIS](#) document to get some ideas for where to start your research!

STEP #1: ANNOTATED Timeline:

Research Question: *What were the social, political and economic issues that **defined** this decade? What lived up to our American Values and what failed to meet them?*

Directions: While researching, record a timeline of the **MOST** key events (according to you) throughout your decade. For each event, write a one sentence explanation why this event is important to your decade. After completing your timeline, think about the **MOST** important events for each year of your decade.

	Political: presidents, activists, policy makers, law, policy, military, war, voting rights, diplomacy, treaties, Supreme Court cases	Economic: taxes, trade, industry, agriculture, banking, currency, consumption, unemployment/employment, debt, inflation, wages, wealth, poverty, labor, class, technology	Social: religion, gender roles, race, family, values, education, entertainment and leisure activities, popular culture, fashion, labor, class, technology, science, philosophy, music, architecture, theater, movies, television, books, poetry, dance, painting, sculpture, slang...
1980	Reagan defeated Jimmy Carter by a landslide. This is very important because it ended the Left wing/New deal coalition that had lasted for decades.	Inflation was at 13.5%. This is important because the economic shortfalls of Carter's presidency set the stage for the Reaganomics of the 80s.	Cable news got launched (CNN). This is important because it created the conditions for the spread of a homogeneous popular culture and later adoption of things like MTV.
1981	Iran hostage crisis ended. This is important because it happened right after Reagan got elected, giving him an immediate victory and giving a contrast between the leadership of Carter and Reagan.	The Economic Recovery Tax Act was passed. This is important because it served as the first building block of 'Reaganomics' and showed people that Reagan was being serious about his reform policies.	MTV launches. This is important because it revolutionized the way the public interacted with and consumed music by turning it from a primarily auditory experience to both a visual and auditory experience.

1982	Reagan's "New Federalism" announced at the State of the Union address. This is important because it changed the previous policy of increasing federal power and more social programs in favor of a cancellation of social programs and a transfer of power to state and local governments.	Unemployment hit double digits. This is important because this is the first time this happened since the 1940s and represented a massive economic crisis within the US.	Michael Jackson released his best-selling album, "Thriller". This is important because it changed the way music videos were used as a promotional platform by creating a template, with the 'Thriller' music video, for future music videos on MTV.
1983	Strategic Defense Initiative (SDI) proposed. This is significant because it was an escalation of Cold War tensions and challenged the pre-existing idea of Mutual Assured Destruction, which had kept nuclear annihilation from happening through the Cold War.	Recovery from the economic recession: unemployment went down to 8%. This is important because it was a successful attempt for the government to intervene in the economy.	MLK holiday created by Ronald Reagan This is important because it marked a huge step in recognizing the struggle that African Americans had to go through to secure their civil rights and celebrated the accomplishments of the civil rights movement.
1984	Ronald Reagan won his re-election in a landslide, securing 49 states. This is important because it showed how much the US public liked Reagan and his policies.	Apple released the Macintosh and sold over 70000 units in its first 100 days. This is important because it popularized the use of a GUI and a mouse, allowing for the personal computer industry to grow rapidly in later years.	1984 Summer Olympics became one of the most successful Olympics in history. This is significant because it marked a shift in the business model of American sport by relying on sponsors rather than government funds.
1985	Gorbachev took power. This is important because it marked the beginning of the end for the Soviet Union, as Gorbachev's policies of perestroika and glasnost weakened the soviet union significantly.	Plaza Accords signed. This is significant because it significantly reduced the value of the American dollar, which in turn reduced US trade deficits and helped to rebalance the global economy.	Live Aid concerts happened. This is significant because it raised a lot of money for countries struck by famine and shows the philanthropic side of American society during the 1980s.
1986	Reagan signs the Tax Reform Act. This is important because it was the most significant tax	Oil prices fell by over half. This is significant because after Saudi Arabia flooded the	Space shuttle Challenger explodes just 70 seconds into its flight. This is significant because it killed 7 astronauts

	decrease since directly after WWII, from around 50% to around 28%. It effectively cemented Reaganomics into the American economic system.	market with oil, the economies of Texas and Oklahoma collapsed almost overnight and directly contributed to the Savings and Loan crisis.	on live television in a mistake that could have been avoidable if they had just checked their O-ring fasteners, showing how internal pressure could affect a lot of technical voices.
1987	Iran-Contra scandal goes public. This is important because it was a huge constitutional scandal where one of the branches of the government was secretly going against the other. The executive branch was able to directly support the Contras by funneling money from selling weapons in Iran to their forces in Nicaragua.	Black Monday stock market crash (Dow down 22 percent in one day). This is significant because it created a feedback loop that destroyed a large portion of the market for almost no explainable reason, showing how fragile our market really is.	ACT UP founded at the height of the AIDS crisis. This is important because it shows how a group can actually stand up and fight for a drug to go through the approval process faster. It showed how the public could speed up the FDA through activism.
1988	George H. W. Bush elected president. This is significant because it proved that the Reagan coalition wasn't just a fluke and was a force that could survive multiple elections/presidents.	US-Canada free trade agreement signed. This is significant because it was basically a blueprint for NAFTA and made free trade an unquestionable staple of American foreign policy.	Prozac was approved by the FDA. This is significant because it showed how the public was reframing depression and other mental illnesses as a disease rather than a moral failure and launched a lot of conversations about mental health.
1989	Berlin Wall falls. This is significant because it was the final nail in the coffin for the USSR. After it happened, the Soviet-aligned countries started to unravel from Russian rule.	The Savings and Loans crisis peaked. This is significant because the deregulation of banks here led to the government having to pay 130 billion dollars to bail out the banks, an enormous sum of money.	Bush declares war on drugs at the height of the crack epidemic. This is important because while it did aim to address a rampant drug issue in America, it allowed for the mass incarceration of primarily minorities, leading to an incarceration crisis that is prevalent in America even 30 years later.

STEP #2: Decade Playlist:

Song Title/Artist/Year	Significance of Song/Why it Represents the Era. Why did you specifically choose this song to show what life was like during your decade?
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Kids in America Kilm Wilde 1981	Kids in America was a song written by British songwriter Kilm Wilde. The song is written from a British perspective as the British youth culture was heavily romanticizing aAmericanteenage life. The new synth energy in the song expressed a cultural shift during the 80s from older punk rock to synth rock and pop, which was brought on because of the importance of consumerism and materialism during the decade. Even though it was written outside of the US and achieved a #2 spot in the UK, it hit top 40s on US billboards, which showed how culture was spreading internationally during this decade. The song shows how materialism of this era, a development aided by Reaganomics, was romanticized by other countries. I chose kids in america because it not only shows the international reach of american culture during the 1980s but shows how prevalent materialism was in 1980s culture as well.
99 Luftballoons Nena 1983	The popularity of the song 99 Luftballoons during this decade is a concrete example of the paranoia over the cold war during this decade and how it permeated not only every day life but international boarders. The song itself is about a fake story in which 99 red balloons are released into the air and are then mistaken for hostile aircraft, causing a world war that destroys the world. Even though the story would never actually happen, it reflects how the public viewed the piece during the cold war as an incredibly fragile thing that could be broken at almost any second by almost anything, like a bunch of red balloons. This song transcended borders too, as this sentiment wasn't unique to america. The song reached #2 in billboards in america, even though it was sung in german and created in germany. Additionally, the song emphasizes how in a world nuclear war, there aren't any real winners with the lyric, "99 years of war leaves no room for victors". The band themselves are from West Berlin, one of the most visible places of the tensions between the eastern and western blocs, as this song was created before the berlin wall fell later in the decade. I chose this song because it reflects just how deeply rooted the paranoia and fear over the cold war was in the society of the 1980s even though it isn't discussed as often.
Goodnight Saigon Billy Joel 1982	Goodnigh Saigon represents the shift in the 80s from protesting the vietnam war to trying to understand the veterans who did go and fight in it. To create the song, Billy Joel interviewed a group of vietnam war veterans to get their stories about their experiences during the war. He attempted to get the sensory experiences, fear, and even ptsd & survivors guilt right in his song. Unlike a lot of other vietnam war protest songs, it talked about the vietnam war from a first person perspective of the people who actually fought in it. Billy Joel was also able to capture the huge generational contrast that had formed in public opinion on servicement, with WWII veterans being praised for their service and Veitname war veterans having to hide the fact that they were a part of the war. These two things combined to give this song its emotional effect. This song was also released just 2 years after ptsd was officially recognized, illustrating how in more than one

	way, the society of the 1980s was trying to understand what it's veterans went through and help them. But the need for this song also highlights the inverse, the public sentiment especially in the early 1980s was very anti-vietnam war, and thus this song was a way to 'protest the protests' if you will or rather a way to help mold the public opinion of the people who fought in the vietnam war as victims and humans rather than evil monsters. The song ultimately reflects how the 1980s culture was still trying to heal the wounds caused by previous decades but was increasingly promoting more understanding than estrangement of our veterans.
Major Tom Peter Schilling 1983	The song is a kindof sequel to Bowie's earlier song, "Space Oddity" about a character named major tom. In this song, the character realizes he loves space and doesn't want to leave even when they try to get him to leave, so he stays up in space. It was released in the exact same year that the plan for SDI was released and its massive popularity in that year reflects a "second wind" for the space race as the american public was getting increasingly fascinated with technology and space during the height of cold war tensions. The deeper reason behind why the character in the song chose to live in space rather than return to earth helps show us how 80s society was becoming incredibly invested in the technology that was being made, but progressively alienated from the world that made them. It helps convey the tensions and fear of annihilation that was felt during that time as the character wants to live in ilsoation far away from american society. The song reflects two parts of american society during the 1980s, one that was very interested in the new technological developments that came along with the space race, and one that was experiencing existential dread because of it. After all, the whole point of the space race was to race to see who could develop the technology to build extremely advanced missiles to wipe out the other one first.
Don't worry be happy Bobby McFerrin 1988	The song itself advertised a message of complacency and just trying to achieve happiness in life. The message comes from an Indian spiritual guru who's sayings appeared in a bunch of posters in the 60s and Bobby himself got the idea from one of his friends apartments. It was an amazing representation of the side of 80s culture that tried to disassociate with what was going on in the world and just enjoy american prosperity. America was doing quite well during this time and there were many new technologies and economic developments on the homefront that people used to help them forget what was going on with the cold war, aids crisis, and rising inequality. It also represents how things like materialism served to distract from other injustices in society, and example of why materialism was such a prevalent thing during this age. George H. W. Bush even adopted the song as his campaign slogan during the 1988 election, showing how american politics had become infected with this idea of complacency. This song is is the epitome of the willful optimism that had permeated 1980s culture, showing how popular culture chose happiness over

	reality.
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STEP #3: ANNOTATED BIBLIOGRAPHIES

Research Question: *What were the social, political and economic issues that **defined** this decade? What lived up to our American Values and what failed to meet them?*

Directions: You will be required to have **THREE annotated bibliographies** by **Tues. 5/19 (1980s, 1990s, and 2000s groups) or Tuesday 5/26 (1960s & 1970s groups).** You need a citation and two paragraphs for each source (5-7 sentences each).

Requirements For Each Source:

1. You need **THREE** sources (database article, primary source, documentary film, feature film, book)
2. Each source will have a full MLA citation
3. Below that citation you will write **two paragraphs**. Your paragraphs will include the following information:
 - a. **1st Paragraph:** Summarizing the source
 - i. What is the source about? Who is the author/creator? What key pieces of information are provided? Is it a primary or secondary source? Is the source credible? How do you know? What specific evidence might you use in your presentation? What did you find most interesting?
 - b. **2nd Paragraph:** Evaluating the Source
 - i. How did this source help you answer your research question? What were you specifically interested in? Did this spark any interest in another topic? Did it cause you to think of any other questions? Did you like this source/was it helpful?

Source #1: (Primary) The 1980's: a decade of job growth and industry shifts
Citation:

Plunkert, Lois M. "The 1980's: A Decade of Job Growth and Industry Shifts." Monthly Labor Review, Bureau of Labor Statistics, Sept. 1990, www.bls.gov/opub/mlr/1990/09/Art1full.pdf.
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(Type your two paragraphs directly in this box)

This source is a primary source from 1990 by the Bureau of Labor Statistics reporting on employment shifts throughout the 1980s. Overall, even though it was a bit uneven, it shows that the US added around 19 million jobs during the 1980s. It shows how the 1980s started off with two major recessions, and then the economy grew with a humungous peacetime economic expansion. The graphs and analysis show that the service sector during the 1980s was rapidly growing, being responsible for around half of all job growth in America during this time. Computers and data jobs more than tripled during these years, and women's workforce participation grew by almost 6% (from 51% to 57%). But, all of this growth was coupled with massive deindustrialization that led to a massive 1.4 million manufacturing jobs being lost as factory jobs were being replaced by machines or simply moved overseas. This source is very credible as it comes directly from the government themselves. It is a direct report from the exact agency in charge of reporting this information. I might use the loss of manufacturing jobs and deindustrialization in my presentation as well as the growth of the service industry, to show how the economy of the US changed so much during the 1980s. I thought that the deindustrialization statistics were the most interesting because I had never realized just how many jobs were lost due to manufacturing changes in the US during the 1980s.

This source shows both the good and bad side of the economic growth that defined the 1980s. Deindustrialization is a prime example of how economic growth failed to meet American values during this decade because working-class Americans were being left behind even though the economy was looking good on paper. The people who were getting laid off from the manufacturing jobs were less educated working-class people, and those getting higher-paying jobs in the service sector were those who were more educated, leaving an entire class of people behind. But the American economy fundamentally grew and changed throughout this decade, which lived up to American values, creating millions of new jobs in the service industry. The 19 million jobs that were added to the United States show just how much the US economy was growing during this period. The source did spark my interest in where the manufacturing jobs that disappeared here in the US actually went. I want to figure out how we decided on where to outsource these jobs to. Although the source definitely raises the question of whether Reagan's economic policies were the ones that worsened the manufacturing decline or if this was something that was coming to the US from the get-go.

Source #2: (Secondary) Savings and Loan Crisis

Citation:

Robinson, Kenneth J. "Savings and Loan Crisis." Federal Reserve History, Federal Reserve Bank, 22 Nov. 2013, www.federalreservehistory.org/essays/savings-and-loan-crisis.

(Type your two paragraphs directly in this box)

The source is an article by the Federal Reserve History about the savings and loan crisis. S&Ls were small community banks that were focused on home mortgages and short-term deposits, but in the 1980s they represented almost half of US home mortgages. The rising inflation and interest rates in the 1980s made the S&Ls have to pay more to attract deposits but were still locked into their old mortgages, meaning they were losing money. This essentially wiped out the entire industry's net worth. The insurance agency that was created to cover the bank losses (FSLIC) only had around 6 of the 25 billion dollars they needed to cover the losses of the S&L banks, so they just let a lot of the banks keep running. These banks started to make riskier investments with the taxpayer money they were given to try to recover, all because deregulation allowed them to. Congress ultimately had to regulate the industry with a massive reform bill that closed hundreds of S&Ls and lost over 407 billion dollars in assets. Because of this, a lot of ordinary people lost their deposits, and the housing market got massively impacted because a lot of banks weren't able to give out as many loans to buy homes. This is a secondary source as it was written in 2013 by a federal history website, although the fact that it was written by a federal history website with citations from sources that were written from 1987 to 1993 gives it a lot of credibility as a source of information. I would use the fact that American taxpayers lost over \$407 billion dollars in assets due to the crisis caused by the deregulation of S&L banks in my presentation, as it shows a side of 80s deregulation that isn't really talked about as much. I thought the fact that these smaller banks would use the tax money they were given to stay afloat to make really risky investments was very interesting, and I had never thought that banks would do that, but it makes sense when you think about it.

This source directly shows how the political decisions of the 1980s, specifically deregulation, caused an economic disaster that went against American values. Ordinary people couldn't get home loans because of the crisis and were essentially paying for the mistakes of a few banks. This was, of course, a massive injustice to those who wanted to buy homes during this time. The source sparked an interest for me in whether or not these deregulation policies under Reagan caused

crises like these in other industries other than just banking. The source also raises the question of why deregulation continued even after the S&L crisis happened, as it caused a lot of damage. Wouldn't people just stop doing the things that were actively causing stuff like this to happen? The source was very helpful in understanding the negative effects of Reagan's policies during the 1980s, as oftentimes deregulation is advertised as a good thing and an example of how the government could save costs for the average citizen, when in fact it causes things to happen that actually hurt the average citizen.

Source #3: (Secondary) What Sparked the Satanic Panic of the 1980s?

Citation:

Little, Becky. "What Sparked the Satanic Panic of the 1980s?" HISTORY, A&E Television Networks, 13 Nov. 2025, www.history.com/articles/what-was-satanic-panic-1980s.

(Type your two paragraphs directly in this box)

The source is an article from [History.com](https://www.history.com), a very reputable source of information, and it discusses the causes of the Satanic Panic in the 1980s. According to the source, the Satanic Panic was a nationwide 'moral' panic where people thought that heavy metal music, fantasy games like D&D, and other things were causing kids to participate in satanic rituals and 'worship the devil'. The source says that this moral panic was most likely a scapegoat for a lot of other anxieties during the time, specifically those caused by Cold War tensions and economic hardships. Children being left at home more frequently, caused by more women entering the workforce, created a new anxiety that these children being left at home were being exposed to dangerous influences while they weren't supervised. A 1980 book called *Michelle Remembers* introduced claims of "satanic ritual abuse" from previous childhood memories, and even though the source has been discredited, it sparked a lot of public anxiety around satanic worship. Heavy metal bands like Mötley Crüe and more were being accused of hiding satanic messaging in their songs. Dungeons and Dragons was accused of promoting witchcraft and dangerous ideas, causing parents to found advocacy groups against it. No evidence of satanic rituals was ever found in any of the cases or investigations during this time. The whole thing was entirely one large mass hysteria panic rooted in shared anxiety from other things during the time, even though it destroyed lives and reputations in the process. The source is a secondary source as it was written after the events took place. I found the piece of evidence about the anxiety that caused it being because more women were entering the workplace, leaving kids at home to be very interesting because it showed an unintended backside to the obvious progress of women entering the workforce, that is that society didn't have the means in place to replace the work that women did in the home before their societal transfer to being more in the workplace. I think I would also use that piece of evidence in my presentation.

This source directly shows how public fear and mass hysteria in the 1980s directly undermined American values by accusing and prosecuting innocent people with zero evidence. The root cause, women entering the workforce, while a major success and development, highlights a lack of support for the children in these families that undermines American values and left a lot of children behind. After reading this source, I thought about whether or not there was any broader pattern of these moral panics in American history or in the conditions that created them. It also brought up the question of whether this spread of misinformation compares to how the media can also spread misinformation and mass hysteria today. This source was definitely more helpful, and it shows a very human side to the decade, as the society of the US was trying to grapple with not only the threat of nuclear annihilation but also the economic change caused by Reaganomics and was just looking for a scapegoat for all of their fears.

